CORE ATTENDEE EDITION: Start with 00_START_HERE.md at the pack root. Only the core two-day route is supplied. Optional publishing, dummy website, resource creation, identity/networking and advanced Azure tracker extensions mentioned below are not assigned or included. Use your own extracted path where a command shows C:\YOUR-ATTENDEE-PACK. Do not copy instructor settings.

Mandatory cost lab - why has the bill increased?

LBS | Attendee edition | Fictional data only | Updated 28 October 2026

Before you start

Expected duration: 75 minutes: 10:00-11:15

Prerequisites: Portal access; assigned cost scope; Labs\Day2Operations\fictional-costs.csv available as fallback.

Required permissions: Read access to the authorised Cost Management scope; Cost Management Reader where applicable. Billing visibility depends on the agreement and administrator settings. Budget writes need separate approval.

Resources created: None. Budget design is required; creating a real budget is an optional authorised extension.

Cost considerations: Cost Analysis views do not create compute. Data can be delayed. No exact current service price is asserted; fictional GBP data is not pricing.

Safety: Use the assigned tenant, subscription and resource only. Do not change shared networking, roles, tiers or deployment settings. No real documents, secrets or keyed URLs in evidence.

What, why and scenario

A fictional operations team reports that spending increased while application traffic appeared stable. Your task is to explain the change before suggesting a safe optimisation.

Cost Analysis reports available cost data. Pricing Calculator estimates a proposed design. A forecast is a prediction, not a final invoice. Actual and amortised cost views answer different questions; record which you use and keep it consistent.

Time split: explain 10 minutes; tutor demo 15; independent practice 30; compare 10; budget/cleanup decision 10.

Portal navigation and expected results

1. Search the portal for Cost Management + Billing. Open Cost Management, select Scope and the assigned subscription or supported resource-group scope. Do not switch to a personal subscription to bypass a restriction.

Expected result: The authorised scope is visible. If unavailable, record live access Blocked and select the prepared route.

2. Open Cost analysis. If a list of views appears, choose Services or a customisable view. If the chart opens directly, use its scope/date controls. Read the currency, period and cost metric before interpreting a number.

Expected result: You can state the scope, currency, dates and Actual/Amortised metric; a blank view is not proof of zero cost.

3. Choose two comparable completed periods, such as equal seven-day windows. Group by Service name; then inspect Resource or Resource group as available. Keep filters and cost metric consistent. Record totals for each period.

Expected result: A comparable breakdown, not a mixture of current partial month and a full prior month.

4. Identify the largest absolute increase and drill into its resources. Note possible usage drivers; do not assume a service name proves the cause.

Expected result: One evidence-based change and a hypothesis requiring further read-only checks.

5. If approved cost data is unavailable or not safe to share, open fictional-costs.csv in a spreadsheet or read-only CSV viewer. Sum Cost separately for each Period and group by Service. Label every figure FICTIONAL.

Expected result: A completed prepared exercise; live cost visibility remains Blocked/Not run. Amounts are invented, not Azure rates.

6. Write one optimisation proposal including evidence, expected saving mechanism, availability/security risk, owner and a verification step. Do not resize, stop or delete anything.

Expected result: A defensible proposal rather than an unapproved production change.

Mandatory budget decision; optional creation

Draft a monthly budget at the appropriate scope with an approved amount, currency, period, owner and notification recipients. For a fictional design example, use GBP 300 with actual-cost notifications at 50%, 80% and 100%; these are invented exercise values, not an LBS spending limit.

Portal route where supported: Cost Management > Budgets > Add. Review scope, reset period, dates, amount and notification conditions. Stop before Create unless the owner explicitly approves a lab budget and recipients. Notification features depend on scope/agreement.

Budget alerts do not automatically stop spending and can arrive after cost data updates. A design or preview is not a created budget. A notification test, if available, is not evidence that a real threshold was crossed.

Troubleshooting - symptom, checks and safe recovery

Symptom	Exact checks / recovery
Access denied / no eligible scope	Verify tenant, subscription and cost visibility with the billing administrator. Request the approved read scope; do not request Owner. Use the fictional CSV.
New resource absent / zero or empty view	Confirm period, filters and billing data freshness; allow the documented data delay. Do not generate expensive usage to make a chart appear.
Totals disagree	Compare scope, currency, equal dates, Actual vs Amortised and filters. Do not mix periods or quotes with actuals.
Budget option missing	Check supported scope/offer and permissions with the owner. Submit the written design; mark creation Not run.

Knowledge check - before and after

Before: how does a calculator estimate differ from a bill? What might keep charging when an app is stopped?

After: which service changed most, and what extra evidence would establish why? Does a budget guarantee spending stops?

Cleanup

No resource deletion is required. Retain only authorised redacted evidence.

Delete only your explicitly approved temporary budget after agreement with its owner; never remove an organisational budget.

Identify plans, storage, monitoring, messaging and networking separately in a cleanup proposal. Deleting one resource is not proof every related charge stops.

Your evidence

Record	Your result
Mode: live / prepared query / offline review	
Scope, time range and source	

Expected / actual result
Passed / Blocked / Not run and why
Cost/security trade-off
Follow-up owner / cleanup

Official reference

https://learn.microsoft.com/azure/cost-management-billing/costs/quick-acm-cost-analysis